Students stall at choosing a fund, not at fees. A neutral side-by-side view helped them choose.

THE QUESTION

Revolut puts cheap index funds inside the bank app. Students who decide to invest search “S&P 500”, find three near-identical funds, and leave.

How can Revolut help a first-time student choose with confidence, without giving advice?

MY ANSWER, IN THREE PARTS

1. **Group funds that track the same index.**
2. **Explain each difference and the risk in plain words.**
3. **Never rank: no badges, no “best”.**

Built only from facts the app already shows on each fund’s page.

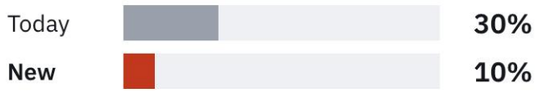
CHOSE A FUND AND COULD SAY WHY



UNDERSTOOD THE RISK



READ THE SCREEN AS ADVICE (LOWER IS BETTER)



NEXT STEP

Help the 40% still stuck, then a controlled experiment.

How it was proven: 4 hypotheses and a decision rule set first · 45 app screens · 6 interviews · 8 requirements · a 30-person prototype test

Evidence: 45-screen walkthrough and 6 interviews (Oct 2026); prototype test with 30 first-time investors, each on both versions (Nov 2026). Early evidence, not proof.

In a 30-person test, the new view lifted confident choices from 40% to 60% and doubled risk understanding.

The test: 30 students from several universities, all first-time investors who had never invested online or used Revolut. Each did the same task on Revolut's current screens and on a prototype of the proposed view. Two rounds: 10 people, then 20 a week later, with the same result.

Chose a long-term fund and could explain why

The core job: pick one, with a reason

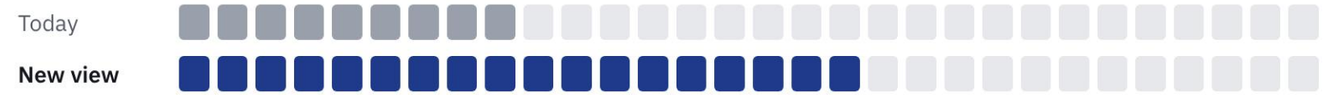


40% → 60%

+20 pts
today → new view

Saw the risk and could explain it

In their own words, before ordering



30% → 60%

2×
today → new view

Read the screen as advice

Thought the app was recommending a fund. Lower is better



30% → 10%

−20 pts
today → new view

Still open

40% still could not choose and explain on the new view: it helps, but does not remove the stall. **1 in 10 still read it as advice**, so the neutral design needs compliance review. Everyone saw both versions, so some of the gain may be practice.

Source: 07-prototype-test/README.md. Prototype sessions run and scored by the author, Nov 2026. 30 people: early evidence, not proof.

Scope, look, listen, decide, then test: every claim has a number, every number a source.

1 Scope

18 Oct

4

Hypotheses written first

Fees, choice, free trades, sign-up.

01-scope/brief.md

1

Decision rule, set in advance

3 of 6 raise it, or 2 stop.

01-scope/research-method.md

2 Look

18 to 19 Oct

45

App screens logged

Invest tab to the order screen.

02-teardown/teardown-log.md

3

Competitors checked

Official fee pages, dated.

02-teardown/alternatives-comparison.md

3 Listen

19 Oct

6

Student interviews

Three segments, past behaviour first.

03-research/synthesis.md

1

Guess of four held up

Choosing, not fees.

03-research/synthesis.md

4 Decide

19 Oct

8

Requirements

6 must-have, each with a pass test.

05-prd/prd.md

1 + 3

Metric and guardrails

First orders up; trading not.

05-prd/prd.md

5 Test

November 2026

30

First-time investors

Each tried both versions.

07-prototype-test/README.md

3 of 3

Measures improved

Choice, risk, advice reading.

07-prototype-test/README.md

RESULT One problem, chosen by a rule written before the first interview, and a fix that moved all three measures in a 30-person test.

Source: the files named under each number, in this repository.

I tested four guesses with an app walkthrough and six student interviews, using a rule set in advance.

1

Walk the app

45 logged screens, from the Invest tab to the order screen (stopped before Submit).

2

Write four guesses

Fees surprise people; funds are hard to find or choose; the free-trade rule confuses; sign-up makes people quit.

3

Interview six students

About past behaviour, not opinions, then a think-aloud task in the app where possible (4 of 6).

4

Apply the rule

Group every friction moment, count who raised it, keep only what passes.

5

Write the fix

A one-page PR/FAQ first, then the PRD with metrics and guardrails.

WHO I SPOKE TO

2 never invested

2 started recently

2 invest regularly

DECISION RULE, WRITTEN BEFORE INTERVIEW ONE

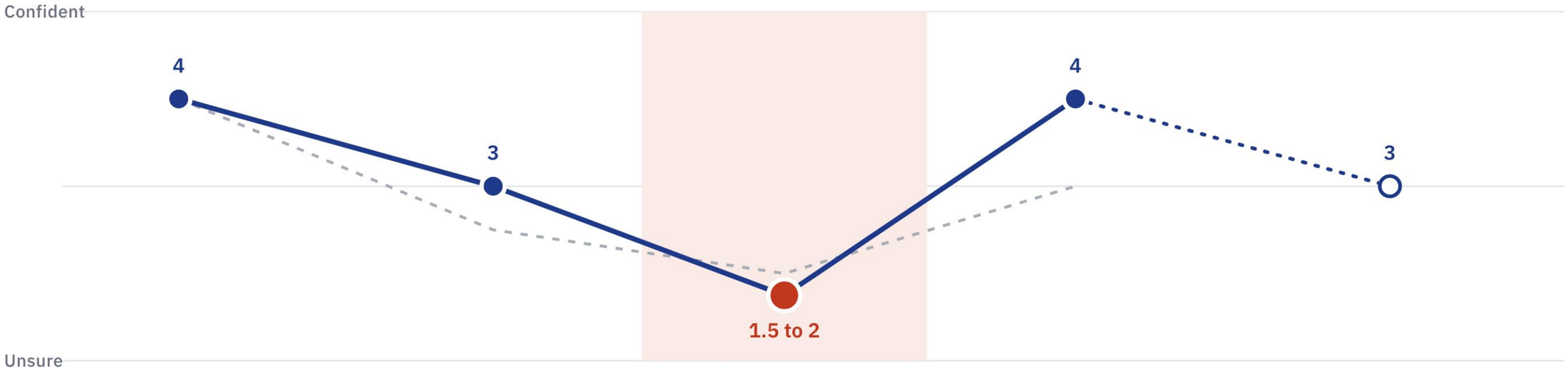
A problem counts only if 3 of 6 raise it unprompted, or 2 say it made them stop.

This stopped me picking the problem I expected. It ruled out fees, my first guess.

Method: Mom Test interviews; Amazon PR/FAQ; jobs to be done. Interviews 3 to 6 recorded with consent and transcribed with AI, then checked.

Students lose the most confidence at one step: choosing between near-identical funds.

How confident students felt at each step of a first fund purchase, from six interviews, against my guess before them.



Arrive
Invest tab sits inside the bank app: easy

Sign up
Extra steps and forms. Annoying; nobody quit

Choose a fund
Three S&P 500 funds, nothing to compare them
Both non-investors left here

Place the order
Simple; costs shown before Submit

Afterwards
Price swings, checking often (one student)

What students described — My guess before the interviews — Scale 1 (unsure) to 5 (confident)

Source: 6 student interviews and an app walkthrough, October 2026. Early evidence, not proof.

Five of six students struggled to pick between similar funds. None were surprised by fees.

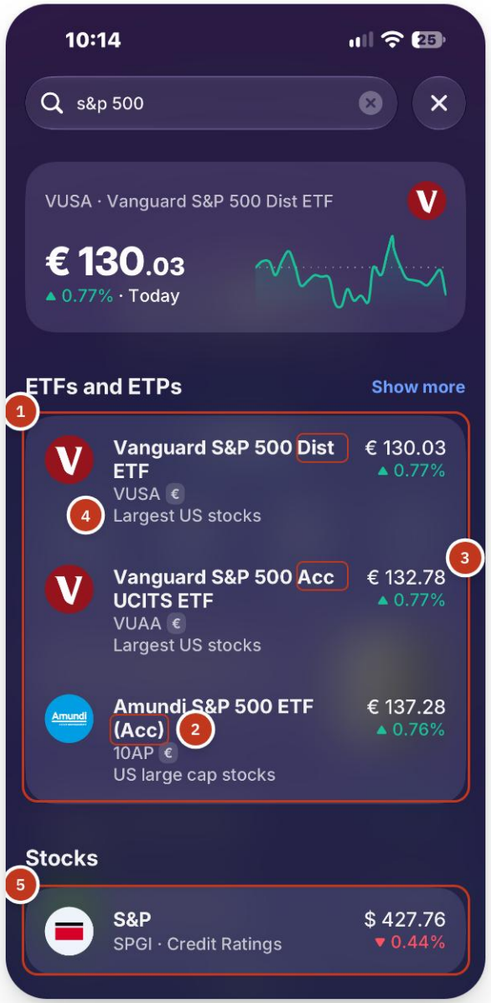
A problem counted only if 3 of 6 raised it, or 2 stopped because of it.

	Never invested		Started recently		Invest regularly			
	P4	P6	P2	P3	P1	P5	Raised by	Verdict
Passed the rule								
Can’t choose between near-identical funds	●	●	●	●	○	●	**5 of 6**	The problem we solve
Didn’t understand the product or the risk	●	●	○	●	●	●	**5 of 6**	Part of the problem
Real, but not the problem								
Left the app to research elsewhere	●	●	○	●	○	●	**4 of 6**	A symptom of it
Bought on news, friends or app suggestions	○	○	●	●	●	○	**3 of 6**	A guardrail
No clear goal or amount in mind	●	●	○	●	○	○	**3 of 6**	Worth watching
Sign-up felt heavy, but nobody quit	○	○	●	●	●	○	**3 of 6**	Friction only
Did not hold up								
Surprised by fees	○	○	○	○	○	○	**0 of 6**	Not a problem here
Free-trade allowance caused a problem	○	○	○	○	○	○	**0 of 6**	Not a problem here

● Raised it ● Raised it, then left the app without buying ○ Did not raise it

Source: 6 student interviews, October 2026. Early evidence, not proof.

Search “S&P 500” and three funds appear, with nothing that says how they differ.



1 Three funds, one index

Vanguard Dist, Vanguard Acc and Amundi Acc all track the S&P 500. Nothing on the screen says so.

2 The only visible difference is jargon

“Dist” and “Acc” decide whether income is paid out or reinvested. There is no explanation.

3 Different prices read as different value

€130, €133 and €137 are prices per unit, not a sign that one fund is better.

4 Three words per fund

“Largest US stocks.” Cost, size and risk are on each fund’s own page, not here.

5 An unrelated company called “S&P”

Further down, CFD versions of S&P 500 funds share near-identical names.

> “The problem wasn’t finding products. It was knowing how to choose between them.”
>
> A student who had never invested, describing this screen

Source: screenshot S40, author’s own account, 19 Oct 2026. Both students who had never invested stopped here and left.

Only one of my starting guesses held up, and in a narrower form than I wrote it.

WHAT I GUESSED BEFORE THE INTERVIEWS	VERDICT	WHAT THE EVIDENCE SHOWED
Fees surprise people on small first purchases	○ Not supported	Nobody was surprised. The order screen shows costs before Submit.
The right funds are hard to find	○ Not supported	Everyone who looked found S&P 500 funds with the search bar.
Choosing between the right funds is hard	● Supported	5 of 6 struggled; both students who had never invested left at that screen.
The free-trade allowance confuses people	◐ Weak	Three could not say their allowance, but it caused nobody a problem.
Sign-up effort makes people quit	○ Not supported	Heavy for three students; nobody quit because of it.

Source: 6 student interviews and app walkthrough, Oct 2026. Verdicts use the decision rule on slide 2.

The fix uses facts the app already has: side by side, in plain words, with no ranking.

A “Same index, what’s different?” view appears whenever two or more funds track the same index.

Reuse what exists

Yearly cost, fund size and a risk score already sit on each fund’s page. **The view puts them together** at the moment of choice.

Translate the jargon

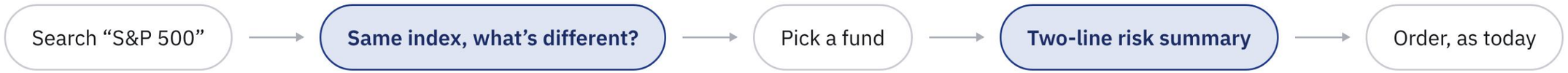
“Dist” and “Acc” become **income paid out** and **income reinvested**. Every row explains itself in one line.

Inform, never advise

Alphabetical order, no “best” badge, no ranking. Under EU rules a personal recommendation is advice; **neutral facts generally are not**.

Risk in two lines

Before a first order: **what you could lose** and how to take money out. Final wording from compliance.



Out of scope on purpose: fees, the free-trade allowance, sign-up, robo-advice, and anything that names a “best” fund.

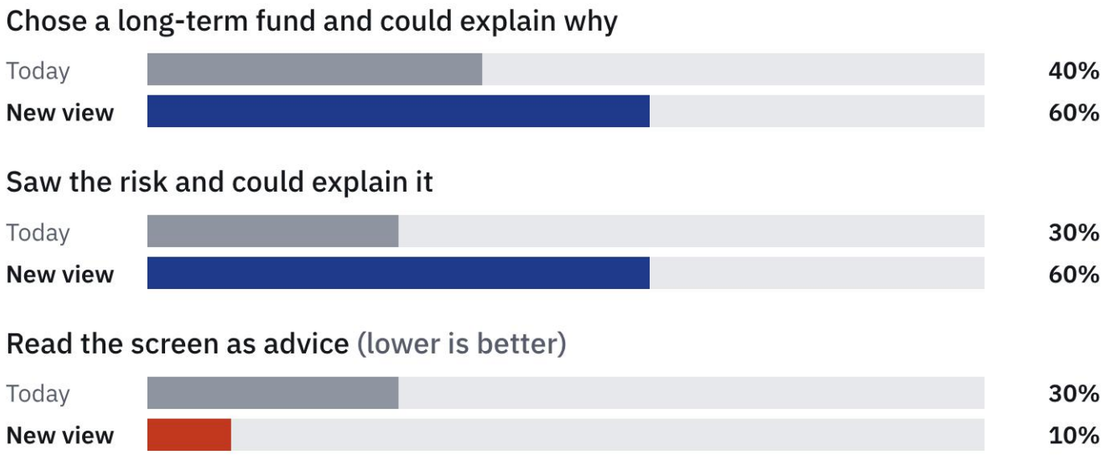
Source: PRD v1.1. Advice boundary: ESMA guidance via law-firm summaries, checked 19 Oct 2026; legal review still needed.

Each part of the fix moved its own measure. Plain-words risk changed most.

GOAL A first-time investor with no help picks a long-term fund, can say why, and understands the risk, without feeling told what to buy.

TEST 30 students, each on Revolut's current screens and on the prototype (two rounds: 10, then 20). I ran and scored every session.

TESTERS WHO GOT IT RIGHT, TODAY AND NEW



WHAT CHANGED, AND WHICH MEASURE IT TARGETS

CHOICE · R1 AND R2
Funds on the same index grouped together, with five plain fields: yearly cost, income paid out or reinvested, size, provider, index.

RISK · R4
A plain-words risk summary before the first order: the value can fall and money can be lost.

ADVICE · R3
No ranking, badge or "best" default; the list is alphabetical.

Still open: 4 in 10 still could not choose and explain, and 1 in 10 still read the view as advice. Next: find what still blocks them, and a compliance review.

Source: 07-prototype-test/README.md; requirements from 05-prd/prd.md. Order of versions not recorded: some gain may be practice.

The prototype passed its first test. The real proof is more first orders without more trading.

PRIMARY METRIC

Of students who open a broad index fund, the share who place a first order within 7 days.

Baseline: to be measured. Target set from the baseline before the test; none invented here.

GUARDRAILS FOR FIRST-TIME INVESTORS

Must not rise	Trades per month
Must not rise	Share of single-stock or leveraged buys
Must not rise	Fee complaints and withdrawals within 30 days

HOW IT GETS TESTED, STEP BY STEP

✓ **Prototype test: done.** 30 first-time investors; confident choices 40% to 60%, risk understood 30% to 60%.

2 **Fix what still blocks the 40%** and get the advice wording through a compliance review.

3 **Controlled experiment** in the EEA, control versus view, long enough to see 7-day first orders.

4 **Go or stop.** Go only if the metric beats a pre-agreed minimum and no guardrail worsens.

What this cannot prove yet: a prototype shows people understand and choose better, not that they will invest more. Only Revolut's data can set the baseline. The deeper cause for some may be "no goal".

Source: PRD v1.1, sections 5, 9 and 10; 07-prototype-test/README.md.

My first guess was wrong. Writing the rule down first is what caught it.

1 Set the bar before the evidence

I expected fees to be the problem. The rule I wrote before interview one ruled it out: 0 of 6 were surprised by fees.

2 Finding is not choosing

Everyone found S&P 500 funds with search. The stall came one step later, between three near-identical funds.

3 Use what the product already has

Cost, size and risk were on every fund page. The fix rearranges facts; it needs no new data.

4 Test cheaply, and report the cost too

A prototype moved all three measures, and also showed 40% still stuck. That number says what to work on next.

LIMITS, STATED PLAINLY

Small samples. 6 interviews and 30 testers are early evidence, not proof.

Both versions, one session. Some of the gain may be practice.

I ran and scored the tests, so my expectations may have shaped the scoring.

Students only, and no access to Revolut's data: the PRD's metric has no baseline yet.

Advice boundary checked from secondary sources; legal review still needed.

Source: 03-research/synthesis.md, 07-prototype-test/README.md, 05-prd/prd.md.